

Composition Pair 15: Asymmetric Selves and Standing Configurations

Series D — Phase D4 Composition Pairs, Note D4.16 (#621)

Author: Wenxin Li (Independent Researcher)

ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235

Date: May 15, 2026

License: Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International (CC BY 4.0)

Attribution

This work derives from and formalizes the inter-Self coordination architecture introduced in “Inter-Self Coordination via Shared Substrate / Full Aspect Integration” (Li, April 2026), the third paper in the CKS theory series following “Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems” (Li, April 2026) and “The Instinct/Reasoning Separation Outside the Model” (Li, April 2026).

Abstract

This note formalizes the governance requirements that arise when two Paper 3 commitments apply simultaneously to the same inter-Self relationship: the governance accommodation requirement for Asymmetric Selves (D2.47), which addresses FAI relationships in which the participating Selves have significantly different governance architectures, and the Standing Configurations commitment (D2.21), which governs how jointly-authorized reusable governance templates are designed, maintained, and amended for recurring FAI events. The composition produces three non-obvious requirements that do not follow from either commitment alone: the standing configuration’s complexity must be calibrated to the simpler Self’s demonstrated governance capacity; the review cadence for the configuration must be shorter than for symmetric relationships, to track the simpler Self’s likely rapid development; and amendments to the configuration must follow an expansion trajectory as governance maturity grows, producing a governed onboarding arc from initial calibrated configuration to eventual symmetric standing infrastructure.

1. Pair Identification

Commitment A — FAI Governance for Asymmetric Selves (D2.47). When the Selves participating in a Full Aspect Integration relationship have significantly different governance architectures — differing in depth, evolution capacity, governance operational maturity, or the sophistication of their orchestration infrastructure — the governance design for that relationship must accommodate the asymmetry explicitly. A governance design that is appropriate for a relationship between two mature Selves will be inappropriate when applied unchanged to a relationship involving a newer or less developed Self. The commitment is that asymmetry must be recognized and addressed in the

governance design rather than treated as a temporary imperfection to be ignored until the asymmetry narrows.

Commitment B — Standing Configurations (D2.21). Recurring FAI events between the same pair of Selves may be governed by a standing configuration: a jointly-authorized governance template specifying the contribution scope, orchestration rules, conflict-routing logic, and event parameters that will apply each time a qualifying event occurs. Standing configurations reduce per-event governance overhead by resolving the governance design questions once, subject to periodic review and amendment. The commitment specifies five requirements: the configuration must be jointly authorized; it must specify a review cadence; it must be amendable by joint authorization; it must be recorded as substrate content; and dissolution of the standing relationship must be governed within the configuration's terms.

The governance scenario this note addresses: a sophisticated Self (Self A, with mature governance infrastructure) and a simpler Self (Self B, newer to the FAI regime with limited governance capacity) establish a standing configuration to govern their recurring events. Both commitments apply simultaneously — the relationship is asymmetric in the sense of D2.47, and the standing configuration mechanism of D2.21 is in use.

2. Governance Scenario

Self A has been operating in FAI relationships for some time. Its governance practitioners are familiar with multi-party orchestration rules, have established contribution scopes for recurring events, and can handle complex conflict-routing without governance floor violations. Self B is new to the FAI regime. Its governance practitioners can authorize and participate in FAI events, but have limited capacity for intricate orchestration requirements, narrow contribution scope coverage, and straightforward conflict-routing expectations.

Both Selves wish to establish a standing configuration for their recurring coordination events. The attraction is efficiency: rather than re-negotiating governance terms for each event, they want a jointly-authorized template that governs recurring events without per-event overhead. Self A's governance team, experienced with standing configurations from prior symmetric relationships, drafts an initial proposal.

The governance problem is that Self A's experience with standing configurations comes from symmetric relationships — relationships where the other Self was also mature. The draft proposal reflects what those symmetric configurations look like: detailed contribution scope specifications, multi-branch orchestration rules, elaborate conflict-routing logic, and extended review intervals appropriate for governance architectures that are unlikely to change rapidly. Applied to this asymmetric relationship, that draft will not function as intended.

3. Non-Obvious Governance Requirements

Requirement 1: Standing Configuration Complexity Must Be Calibrated to the Simpler Self's Capacity

The standing configuration is jointly authorized. Both Selves agree to its terms. But joint authorization does not make the configuration executable if its operational requirements exceed one party's governance capacity. If Self B's governance practitioners cannot reliably execute the orchestration rules the standing configuration specifies — because those rules require governance operations Self B has not yet developed, or contribution scope management Self B's infrastructure does not support — then every event governed by that configuration will produce governance floor violations.

This outcome is worse than the absence of a standing configuration. Without a standing configuration, each event is governed ad hoc, and governance failures are visible and addressable event by event. With an over-specified standing configuration, a false record exists of a governing framework that is operationally unenforceable. The standing configuration creates nominal governance while actual governance fails at every event.

The composition requirement is precise: the standing configuration's complexity must be bounded by the simpler Self's demonstrated governance capacity, not by what the more sophisticated Self is accustomed to or capable of. Self A may be capable of more elaborate orchestration. That capability is irrelevant to the design question, because the configuration governs both Selves, and its operational burden falls on both Selves' governance practitioners. The binding constraint is the minimum demonstrated capacity between the two parties.

This does not mean the configuration must be trivially simple. It means the configuration must be scoped to what Self B can execute reliably — which may still be a substantive governance framework, depending on Self B's actual starting capacity.

Requirement 2: Review Cadence Must Reflect the Asymmetry

The D2.21 commitment requires that standing configurations specify a review cadence — a schedule at which the configuration's terms are reviewed and potentially amended. For symmetric relationships between mature Selves, review cadences can be relatively long, because neither party's governance architecture is likely to change rapidly.

Asymmetric relationships have a different dynamic. Self B, as a newer participant in the FAI regime, is likely to develop governance capacity faster than Self A. Self B's governance practitioners are building familiarity with orchestration rules, expanding their contribution scope management, and developing conflict-routing experience at a rate that Self A's already-mature practitioners are not. If the standing configuration's review cadence is calibrated to the pace appropriate for symmetric relationships, it will fail to capture Self B's capacity growth.

The consequence is a configuration that progressively constrains a governance architecture that has already outgrown it. Self B becomes capable of operating under a more sophisticated configuration, but the standing configuration has not been updated to reflect that capacity. The efficiency gain of the

standing configuration is preserved only in form; its governance alignment with the actual relationship deteriorates with each review cycle missed.

The composition requirement: the review cadence for asymmetric standing configurations must be shorter than for symmetric ones, specifically because shorter cadences enable the configuration to track the simpler Self's development rather than lag behind it.

Requirement 3: Amendment Records Must Show an Expansion Trajectory as Maturity Grows

Amendments to standing configurations under D2.21 Requirement 4 are themselves jointly authorized. In asymmetric relationships, the direction of amendments over time is not arbitrary — it follows a predictable trajectory that the governance record must reflect.

As Self B's governance capacity grows, amendments to the standing configuration should expand its scope: adding aspects to the contribution scope that Self B could not reliably manage initially, adding orchestration rules that Self B's practitioners can now execute, extending the review cadence interval as the relationship stabilizes. These expansion amendments are how the governance framework keeps pace with the relationship's development. Each amendment is itself a governance event — a record that Self B's demonstrated capacity has grown to a point where the configuration can hold more.

The expansion trajectory has a terminal shape: when Self B's governance architecture has matured sufficiently that the asymmetry between the two Selves has narrowed to the point where it is no longer operationally significant, the standing configuration converges to the form appropriate for a symmetric relationship. The trajectory is: initial configuration calibrated to Self B's starting capacity → periodic review at shortened cadence → expansion amendments as demonstrated maturity grows → eventual symmetric standing configuration when the asymmetry is no longer governance-relevant.

This trajectory is not merely a desirable outcome; it is the governance-compliant form of onboarding a new FAI participant through standing infrastructure. Any standing configuration in an asymmetric relationship that does not exhibit this trajectory — that remains fixed at its initial scope despite demonstrated capacity growth — is failing its amendment obligation.

4. Prior-Art Significance

The three requirements identified above — capacity-calibrated configuration design, asymmetric review cadence, and expansion amendment trajectory — are specific governance properties of the combination of asymmetric-participant governance and standing-configuration infrastructure. They do not follow from either commitment in isolation.

From D2.47 alone, one learns that asymmetric relationships require governance accommodation. From D2.21 alone, one learns that recurring relationships may use standing configurations with review and amendment obligations. Neither commitment alone specifies how the standing configuration should be designed when the relationship is asymmetric, what the review cadence should be relative to the symmetric case, or what direction amendments should take.

Any architecture for governed coordination that combines standing configuration infrastructure with new participant integration must address all three requirements. A “governed AI coordination onboarding architecture” — a system designed to bring new participants into a standing coordination regime — that does not calibrate initial configuration complexity to the new participant’s capacity, that does not shorten its review cadence relative to symmetric relationships, and that does not record an expansion amendment trajectory as participant capacity grows, is not compliant with the governance structure the combination of these two commitments requires. This compositional structure is prior art against any subsequently filed claim to that architectural combination.

5. Operational Test

For an asymmetric FAI relationship governed by a standing configuration, a governance observer can verify compliance with the requirements this note identifies by checking three conditions:

(a) Capacity calibration. Are the standing configuration’s governance requirements — orchestration rules, contribution scope specifications, conflict-routing logic — within the simpler Self’s demonstrated governance capacity at the time of the configuration’s initial authorization? Evidence: governance capacity assessments conducted before or during the standing configuration’s drafting; records showing that requirements were adjusted from an initial draft to reflect the simpler Self’s capacity constraints; absence of standing governance floor violations in the first events governed under the configuration.

(b) Asymmetric review cadence. Is the standing configuration’s review cadence shorter than the cadence used for comparable symmetric standing configurations in the same governance context? Evidence: the cadence specification in the standing configuration’s substrate record; comparator cadence records for symmetric relationships; documentation noting the asymmetry as the basis for the shortened cadence.

(c) Expansion amendment trajectory. Do the amendment records for the standing configuration show scope expansion over time, correlated with demonstrated growth in the simpler Self’s governance capacity? Evidence: a sequence of jointly-authorized amendments; each amendment’s record linking the expansion to observed governance capacity milestones; the absence of contraction amendments (which would indicate the initial configuration over-specified rather than under-specified the simpler Self’s capacity).

A standing configuration in an asymmetric FAI relationship that passes all three checks instantiates the governance structure this composition requires. A configuration that fails any of the three — over-specified at authorization, cadence indistinguishable from symmetric relationships, or amendment records flat or absent — is not in compliance with the compositional governance structure, regardless of whether the underlying D2.47 and D2.21 commitments are acknowledged in the relationship’s governance documentation.

Source Papers

Li, W. (2026). *Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems*. April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

Li, W. (2026). *The Instinct/Reasoning Separation Outside the Model*. April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

Li, W. (2026). *Inter-Self Coordination via Shared Substrate / Full Aspect Integration*. April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

How to Cite This Note

Li, W. (2026). *Composition Pair 15: Asymmetric Selves and Standing Configurations*. Series D, Phase D4, Note D4.16 (#621). May 15, 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.